

Derek Staley

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Summary

Delivery and program leader with 13 years across tech, games, and entertainment. I've launched new products and verticals, built Agile delivery from scratch, and kept cross-functional teams aligned through complex execution. Now I'm moving into product management, and I've built two products end to end. Case studies available at dcstaley.github.io.

Independent Product Development

Unified Tasks & Habits App | Personal Project, 2026 – Present · productivity-app-five-eta.vercel.app (desktop only)

A local-first app that unifies tasks, habits, and calendar events on one view. All requirements, specs, and roadmap owned by me. Built with Claude Code.

- Designed the app around a single item model, where a task, a calendar event, and a habit are one underlying item with time, repeat, and tracking as optional layers. It closes the gap left by tools that keep the three apart
- Owned the PRD, user stories with acceptance criteria, a competitive analysis, and the information and technical architecture, versioned and kept current as the build proceeded
- Shipped v1 in three planned phases, covering flexible scheduling, habit tracking, tags, notes, completion history, Google Calendar sync, and week/month views
- v2 in active development, adding analytics, reminders, and richer habit goals, prioritized from features intentionally deferred out of v1

Roster Optimizer for Out of the Park Baseball | Personal Project, 2025 – Present

An analytics web app for a baseball simulation video game. All requirements, scoring logic, and feature specs owned by me. Built with Claude Code.

- Diagnosed v1's failure with a file-by-file audit (scores computed two different ways), then rebuilt around a single scoring core consumed identically by the grid, optimizer, and validation, removing the drift behind most of v1's bugs
- Made the prediction model a swappable component and let a bake-off on real season outcomes choose it, retiring "match the old app's scores" as the goal once the data-trained model won
- Specified a HiGHS linear-programming optimizer for optimal 26-player rosters under budget, eligibility, tier, two-way, and lineup constraints; live in competitive play

Selected Professional Work

Producer, Demiurge Studios

2023 – 2025

- Led feature prioritization and roadmap planning for Riot Games across Teamfight Tactics and 2XKO, balancing product vision, design intent, and technical feasibility
- Turned product direction from Riot's product and design leads into clear, well-scoped plans with defined acceptance criteria
- Kept Riot's game teams and Demiurge's engineering and art aligned on requirements, priorities, and deliverables across both engagements

Program Manager, MGM Resorts International

2021 – 2023

- Built production and delivery processes for a newly formed product and development team, including agile workflow, backlog management, sprint cadence, and tooling
- Partnered with finance and business stakeholders on budget planning, staffing, and resource decisions across multiple concurrent roadmaps
- Collaborated with the Lead Product Manager on roadmap planning to establish realistic timelines and prioritization

Senior Project Manager, The Zebra

2019 – 2021

- Joined as an early PM hire and established company-wide best practices, policies, and tooling from the ground up
- Led the launch of the home insurance vertical, the first major extension of the core business, from initial scoping through go-to-market execution
- Established executive-level reporting dashboards providing visibility into delivery health, blockers, and progress as the organization scaled
- Mentored engineering leads and managers on Agile processes, estimation, and backlog prioritization

Agile Project Manager, Confluence Inc

2017 – 2019

- Led the dev support team, designing processes for prioritizing client requests alongside planned development work
- Established company-wide processes to predict and communicate the timing of bug fixes, patches, and new features, improving client satisfaction and stakeholder transparency
- Led the transition of a 20-year-old engineering team onto modern agile processes, including backlog management, sprint planning, and retrospectives

Project Manager, Ellation (Crunchyroll)

2016 – 2017

- Led the launch of VRV, a new video streaming platform, simultaneously shipping on iOS, Android, Xbox One, and PS4 and hitting all target launch dates through tight scope and resourcing decisions
- Created dashboards surfacing critical path items and blockers for both engineering teams and executive leadership
- Partnered with technical leadership to implement live deployment processes across all backend services

Project Manager, Big Fish Games

2015 – 2016

- Ran planning and execution for live updates on a top-10 grossing iOS and Android game, coordinating across development, product, QA, and marketing

Project Manager, Branding Brand

2013 – 2014

- Managed delivery for remote international client teams and launched the company's first international travel site

Associate Product Manager, Kixeye

2011 – 2013

- Partnered with game design and UX to build, test, and ship new features, owning quality from development through launch

Skills

Product: Product Management, Product Roadmapping, Feature Prioritization, Product Discovery, PRDs, User Stories & Acceptance Criteria, Competitive Analysis

Delivery: Backlog Management, Agile, Scrum, Kanban, Jira, Confluence, Program Management, Project Management

Leadership & Collaboration: Cross-functional Leadership, Stakeholder Management, Executive Communication, Team Mentorship

AI & Data: AI-Directed Development, Generative AI, Prompt Engineering, Claude Code, Data Analysis

Certifications: Certified Scrum Master (CSM)

Education

B.S., Information Science and Technology — Penn State University